

Merychippus

MEH-ree-KIP-us

- **When** 17–10 million years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** USA, Mexico
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Grass



Merychippus was the first horse thought to have fed only on grass, unlike its leaf-eating ancestors. It was also the first to have a head similar to a modern horse's, with a long muzzle, deep jaws, and eyes set on either side of its head. Its neck was long, so it was able to graze on grass comfortably. *Merychippus* lived in large herds, traveling long distances to feed. It could run fast on its long legs, even breaking into a gallop when chased by predators.

Protorohippus

PRO-tore-oh-HIP-us



- **When** 52–45 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 1 ft (0.3 m)
- **Diet** Plants

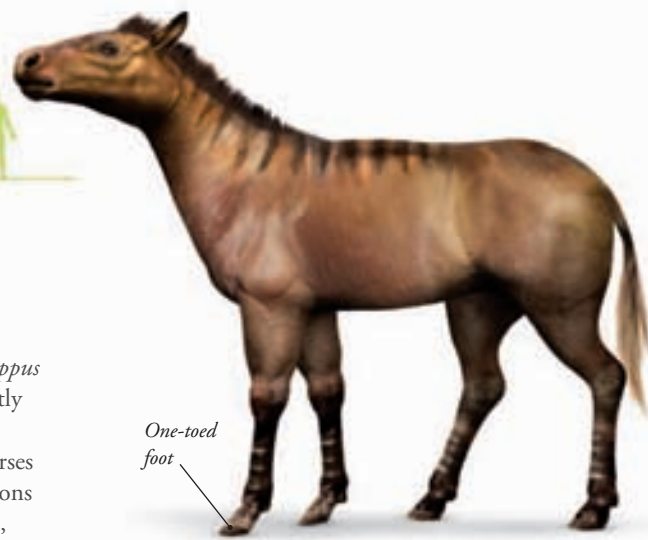
One of the earliest known horses, tiny *Protorohippus* was a forest-dwelling animal that perhaps lived on its own or in pairs, mostly eating leaves rather than grass. It had very short limbs, with hind legs slightly longer than its fore legs, which suggests that it was a good jumper. Of its three toes, the middle one was enlarged and carried the weight of the animal.

Pliohippus

PLY-oh-HIP-us

- **When** 12–2 million years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Until recently, scientists thought *Pliohippus* was the ancestor of modern horses, partly because it walked on single-toed feet. However, it had curved teeth (other horses had straight teeth) and strange depressions on its face. With its long, slender limbs, *Pliohippus* was built for speed.



Equus

ECK-wuss

- **When** 4 million years ago to now (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Worldwide
- **Habitat** Plains and grasslands
- **Length** 9 ft (3 m)
- **Diet** Grass



The name *Equus* includes all modern horses, from racehorses and domestic donkeys to wild zebras. Outside Africa, wild horses are now rare. *Equus* horses clearly show the much bigger brains that are typical of later mammals. Medium to large in size, they have long heads and long, maned necks. They can run fast, especially when threatened, and live in herds.

LIVING RELATIVE

Modern horses are large, fast-running mammals with slender legs ending in single-toed, hoofed feet. They have long heads, long tails, and manes of hair on the neck. Today, there are more than 400 breeds of domestic horse but only seven wild species, including zebras and onagers.



Mesohippus

MEE-zoe-HIP-us

- **When** 40–30 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 2 ft (0.5 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Mesohippus ("middle horse") had features of both early and later horses. Like modern horses, it had a long snout with a gap between its front and back teeth. A fast runner, its long, slender legs resembled those of today's horses, except that *Mesohippus*'s feet had three toes. It probably fed on bushes and trees, chewing the leaves with teeth smaller than those of grass-eating horses.

